

APPENDIX IIDOCUMENTATION OF RARE BIRD SIGHTINGS
FOR
THE COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS' RECORDSSpecies: Black Vulture ; Coragyps atratus
(Vernacular name) (Scientific name)

If you watch birds solely for your own enjoyment, a written description of your observations is unnecessary. But, if you have seen something unusual, and would like to share this with others, a written description is essential. Compilers of regional bird lists must insist that their records be scientifically sound; future bird students -- those studying occurrences 50 years from now -- must have a written record on which to depend. By providing the verifying written description, you are employing a basic rule of the scientific method.

We recognize that experienced field observers can provide important and reliable records, if supported by an adequate verifying description. Thus this request is an effort to perpetuate your record by obtaining concrete evidence which may be permanently preserved for examination by others in the future. This procedure is required for every extraordinary observation, irrespective of the observer.

Dates (s): 6 June 1978 Time Bird Seen: 8:11 a.m. to 8:16 a.m.Locality : Pawnee National Grassland, north and east of
Nunn, Weld County, Colorado
Nearest town, county and state:Optical equipment: Bushnell 7 X 35 binocularsIf photographed, please enclose copy. Equipment used: —Number of birds seen: 1 Sex: ? Plumage: AdultLight conditions: Bright, sunny. Cloud cover - 10%.Distance from bird, and how measured: 200 feet. Estimation

Describe the bird's overall behavior:

The bird was soaring, with relatively short glides, followed by rapid wingbeats.

Describe the habitat in which you observed the bird:

Short-grass prairie, including Opuntia and Atriplex.

Other observers who independently identified this bird (Please list name and address):

No other observers

APPENDIX II Continued

Describe in great detail the bird which you saw. Emphasize particularly the field marks used to identify the bird, but include a complete description of the bird. Include size, overall shape, plumage and color pattern; details on shape or size of bill, wings, and tail. (Reference to its resemblance to field guide descriptions is not enough). Describe what you actually saw in the field.

Medium-sized soaring bird. Wings held straight out. Tips of wing feathers slotted. Black head, dark feet. Underneath profile appeared all dark, except for white patches at the outside edges of the wings. Tail quite short - did not appear to extend beyond the feet in flight.

Describe the bird's calls or sounds, if heard; including method of delivery-- i.e., from perch, in flight, etc.:

No calls or sounds heard.

List similar species and how you eliminated them:

Turkey Vulture - Tail too short, head black, wingspread too short, white on wings restricted patches at edges. Glide too short.

- Too early in season for juvenile turkey vulture which sometimes has black head.

Prior experience with this and similar species:

I have no previous experience with black vultures, but considerable experience with turkey vultures, having observed them numerous times in the field.

This report was written from notes made during X after observation; from memory .

Name (print) : Thomas E. Olson

Mailing address: 30-E South Aggie Village, Fort Collins, Colo. 8052

Signature: Thomas E. Olson

Return Form To:

CFO Records Committee
c/o Curator - Dept. of Zoological Collections
Denver Museum of Natural History
City Park
Denver, CO 80205

30-E South Aggie Village
Fort Collins, Colorado 8052

26 June, 1978

CFO Records Committee
c/o Curator - Dept. of Zoological Collections
Denver Museum of Natural History
City Park
Denver, Colorado 80205

Gentlemen:

I observed a black vulture (Coragyps atratus) 6 June 1978 while running a mourning dove call count on the Pawnee National Grassland in Weld County, Colorado. Although I've never previously observed a member of this species, I have had considerable prior experience with turkey vultures. There are no other species that are similar enough to be considered.

I am a graduate student majoring in Wildlife Biology at Colorado State University. My master's study concerns mourning doves and land-use changes in northeastern Colorado. I work on the Pawnee National Grassland two to three times per week. I have been quite active in birding for about four years, so I realize the importance of a rare bird sighting. I wouldn't report the sighting unless I was sure of it.

If there are any questions, please contact me.

Sincerely,

Thomas E. Olson
30-E South Aggie Village
Fort Collins, Colorado 80521
482-2597

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS RECORDS COMMITTEE

REPORT 1977-1980--Part 1.

by Charles A. Chase III

Assistant Curator, Zoological Collections

Denver Museum of Natural History, Denver, Colorado 80205

This report contains the results of records reviewed by the Colorado Field Ornithologists Records Committee (R.C.) from 1977, 1978, 1979, and 1980. Activities of the R.C. from its inception in May 1972 through 1977 have been reported by Reddall (1973a,b,c; 1974a,b; 1975; 1976a,b) and Andrews (1978, 1979). The list of Colorado birds as recognized by the R.C. stands at 429 species as of 1 January 1981.

The R.C. currently consists of nine members: Robert Andrews (Denver), Charles Chase (Longmont-Chairman), David Griffiths (Pueblo), Edward Hollowed (Meeker), Harold Holt (Denver), Tim Manolis (Boulder), Peter Moulton (Niwt), Ronald Ryder (Ft. Collins), and Richard Stransky (Durango). All R.C. records are deposited in the Department of Zoological Collections, Denver Museum of Natural History.

All records received are reviewed by the committee and rated according to an A-B-C-D system. A is a record for which the submitted documentation supports the stated or claimed identification. B indicates that the submitted documentation indicates a misidentification was probably made. C indicates that the submitted documentation is too brief or incomplete to allow its inclusion in either of the two previous categories. D is used when a member is reviewing his/her own record or is unfamiliar with the species in question and can give no opinion. A record, once completed will be resubmitted through the Committee only if an error was made initially or if new information regarding the identification of the species in general is brought forward. Since all records are stored at the Museum and are open to the public, anyone may use these records as they wish.

The following is the list of species for which the R.C. desires documentation (in addition to any species unrecorded from Colorado):

Red-throated Loon, Red-necked Grebe, Brown Pelican, Olivaceous Cormorant, Anhinga, Little Blue Heron, Reddish Egret, Louisiana Heron, Wood Stork, Glossy Ibis, Roseate Spoonbill, Trumpeter Swan, Brant, European Wigeon, Harlequin Duck, Black Scoter, Swallow-tailed Kite, Red-shouldered Hawk, Gyrfalcon, Whooping Crane (except W. slope), King Rail, Yellow Rail, Purple Gallinule, Common Gallinule, American Woodcock, Eskimo Curlew, Sharp-tailed Sandpiper, Hudsonian Godwit, Ruff, Red Phalarope, all Jaegers, Great Black-backed Gull, Lesser Black-backed Gull, Thayer's Gull, Laughing Gull, Little Gull, Ivory Gull, Black-legged Kittiwake, Arctic Tern, Caspian Tern, Ancient Murrelet, White-winged Dove, Groove-billed Ani, Barred Owl, Spotted Owl, Boreal Owl, Whip-poor-will, Lesser Nighthawk, Anna's, Rivoli's, and Blue-throated Hummingbirds, Olivaceous Flycatcher, Black Phoebe, Alder Flycatcher, Eastern Wood Pewee, Vermilion

Flycatcher, Purple Martin (E. slope only), Short-billed Marsh Wren, Long-billed and Bendire's Thrashers, Gray-cheeked Thrush, Sprague's Pipit, Phainopepla, White-eyed Vireo, Yellow-throated Vireo, Swainson's, Blue-winged, Lucy's, Cape May, Hermit, Cerulean, Yellow-throated, Pine, and Prairie Warblers, Louisiana Waterthrush, Kentucky, Connecticut, Mourning, and Canada Warblers, Painted Redstart, Eastern Meadowlark (except at Red Lion State Wildlife area), Scott's Oriole, Great-tailed Grackle (except San Luis Valley), Hepatic Tanager, Painted Bunting, LeConte's, Sharp-tailed, Baird's, and Golden-crowned Sparrows.

Part I -- Species added to the Colorado list

PURPLE GALLINULE (*Porphyryla martinica*). One adult (17-78-55) approximately 8 mi. south of Durango, La Plata Co., 6 and 7 Aug 1978. The R.C. has received reports from Dr. Howard Winkler and Elva Fox, who also provided an exceptionally sharp and clear photograph of this bird. While the possibility of this bird being an escape cannot be totally eliminated, the date of observation and location in southwestern Colorado make it very likely that this bird is a post-breeding wanderer from Arizona. Gallinules as well as most other members of the Rallidae are renowned for their post-breeding wanderings. The white upper frontal shield, reddish bill with a yellow tip, as well as the purple coloration are well described in the reports in addition to being very obvious in the photo.

GREAT BLACK-BACKED GULL (*Larus marinus*). One immature (23-80-14) Centennial Park, Arapahoe Co., 1 Jan - 30 Jan or possibly into the first week of Feb 1980. This bird was first reported by Jack Reddall and J.V. Remsen on 1 Jan and was subsequently seen by more than 25 observers. Reports have been received by the R.C. from only three observers: Tim Manolis, Bruce Webb, and Charles Chase with photos from the latter two. This is an extremely poor reporting rate that could have resulted in the species not being added to the state list had the few reports and photos received not adequately documented this occurrence. The R.C. would still appreciate any additional reports on this or any other species.

The extremely large size (though smaller than many observers had thought), the tail with a white background and extensive mottling and heavy flight characteristics eliminate all other immature gulls. A photograph of the tail while the bird is in flight is on file with the R.C., courtesy of Bruce Webb.

ALDER FLYCATCHER (*Empidonax alnorum*). An earlier specimen, DMNH 36457, than has been previously reported was located at the Denver Museum of Natural History. One male taken 28 May 1904 on Clear Creek, Arvada, Jefferson Co., by H.G. Smith. The bird was identified by Dr. A.R. Phillips, who will provide a short article to the C.F.O. Journal, in the near future, on how to identify and separate alder and willow flycatchers.

MOURNING WARBLER (*Oporornis philadelphia*). One immature (DMNH

34586) Sedalia, Douglas Co., 18 Oct 1964. Mist netted and collected by Mildred Snyder.

Part II--Reported species not added to the Colorado list

Reports of the following species not currently on the Colorado list of birds were received and reviewed by the R.C.. For the reasons stated, none of these species was added to the Colorado list.

BLACK-BELLIED WHISTLING DUCK (*Dendrocygna autumnalis*). One (8-78-74) observed near Silt, Garfield Co., on 27 May 1978. The basis of this identification seems to be that since the duck appeared to land in a tree and was dark colored (?) it was a tree duck. Since mallards and other ducks are known to land in trees and with the acute lack of details accompanying this report, this species was not added to the Colorado list.

RUDDY SHELDUCK (*Tadorna ferruginea*). Two (8-79-21) at Cherry Creek Res., Arapahoe Co., 16 Oct 1978. Both this and the next report are considered to be escapes from one of the many waterfowl breeders in the area, especially since neither of these is ever expected to turn up in Colorado. If local breeders would either band or pinion their birds it would make it easier to distinguish between wild and escaped captive birds.

RED-CRESTED POCHARD (*Netta rufina*). One male (8-78-67) at Chatfield Res., Douglas Co., 17 Sept 1978. Noted above.

BLACK VULTURE (*Coragyps atratus*). One bird (9-78-75) was sitting on a roof in Boulder, Boulder Co., 10 Sept 1978. While the details of this bird while perching (large, all black bird with a shiny black, bald head and short tail) tend to support this identification, the lack of flight details, extremely abnormal flight behavior, and no other reports force the R.C. not to add this species to the state list. Reporters should be aware that immature turkey vultures have very dark heads and possibly partially grown tails that could give the appearance of a black vulture. Since this bird is reported as flying with difficulty it is quite possibly a very young turkey vulture.

BLACK VULTURE (*Coragyps atratus*). One (9-78-54) at Pawnee National Grasslands, Weld Co., 6 June 1978. While this report contains very good details and undoubtedly describes a black vulture, the fact that only a single observer is involved precludes it from being added to the state list. It will be added to the hypothetical list based on this and other single observer reports over the years.

ZONE-TAILED HAWK (*Buteo albonotatus*). One (10-80-3) near mile marker "7" on Hwy. 101 south of Las Animas, Bent Co., 2 Nov 1979. This single observer report does not adequately eliminate the rough-legged hawk, which is the common hawk in this area in November. The banded tail does occur occasionally in rough-legs as well as in immature Harlan's type redtails which are also to be found in SE Colorado.

WESTERN GULL (*Larus occidentalis*). One adult (23-79-6) at Cherry Creek State Recreation Area, Arapahoe Co., 23 May 1978. This report contains very few details especially for comparing with similar species. A report of a new state bird has to show adequate details to at least describe the bird, its situation, other birds present, etc., even if the species is relatively easy to identify.

MEW GULL (*Larus canus*). One (23-80-37) Centennial Park, Arapahoe Co., 27 Jan 1980. The details of this single observer report do not adequately eliminate ring-billed gull though it is a strong possibility that this was a mew gull.

RUBY-THROATED HUMMINGBIRD (*Archilochus colubris*). One adult male (31-80-1) Beulah, Pueblo Co., 31 Aug 1979. This report is another case of an observation that is probably correct but similar species are not adequately eliminated, in this case the broad-tailed hummingbird is a significant possibility. At this date (31 Aug) broad-tails should be undergoing molt which could easily result in a forked tail and reduced or non-existent sound from the primaries, which is the source of the buzzing sound.

MEXICAN JAY (*Aphelocoma ultramarina*). One (37-78-68) Colorado Springs, El Paso Co., 6 Sept 1978. This report distinguishes Mexican from scrub jays on the basis of "no white throat." Since both immature and Woodhouse's type scrub jays have dingy gray throats and are present in this area in early September, it seems quite likely that this bird is not a Mexican jay. Mexican jays have no history of wandering anywhere near Colorado.

WHEATEAR (*Oenanthe oenanthe*). Twenty (44-79-3) Mount Evans, Clear Creek Co., 4 Sept 1978. This flock was observed while facing the sun and while the flock was flying into the sun. There are very scanty details and no other observers. The description given fits female and immature mountain bluebirds much closer than it does wheatears. Due to the apparent misidentification this species was not added to the state list.

BLACK-TAILED GNATCATCHER (*Poliophtila melanura*). One pair (N-45-80) 2 mi. north of Ridgway, Ouray Co., 12-14 May 1977. This species is quite restricted to desert scrub of the Southwest and is not known to wander. No calls were noted, and the birds were found in riparian habitat. The description is not nearly exhaustive enough for a new state species let alone one that is as difficult to differentiate from the blue-gray gnatcatcher as this species is.

BLACK-TAILED GNATCATCHER (*Poliophtila melanura*). One (48-78-7) Browns Park NWR, Moffat Co., 30 June 1977. This single observer report provides very few details except that the bird appeared to have a black cap. Since blue-gray gnatcatchers can actually have a darker contrasting cap than pictured in field guides and are common in this area, it is felt by the R.C. that there are not enough details to add this species to either the state or hypothetical lists.